Northwind Collective — Employee Handbook

Effective 2026, 15th edition. This handbook supersedes all previous editions.

Chapter 1: Welcome and Company Overview

Northwind Collective was founded in 2014 and now employs approximately 1,200 people across six countries. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

The company's headquarters is in Lisbon, Portugal, with regional offices in Austin, Nairobi, and Singapore. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

The Chief Executive Officer is Renata Okafor, who has held the role since 2019. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 2: Onboarding

New hires complete a five-day onboarding program before joining their team. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Every new hire is assigned a buddy from a different department for their first ninety days. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Laptop and equipment setup must be completed by IT before the new hire's start date, not on it. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 3: Working Hours and Flexibility

Core collaboration hours are 10:00 to 15:00 in the employee's local time zone. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Employees may start their workday any time between 7:00 and 10:00. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Compressed four-day work weeks require written approval from both the manager and HR. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 4: Remote Work

Employees who have completed a 90-day probationary period may work remotely up to three days per week. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Fully remote arrangements beyond three days per week require Vice President approval. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

International contractors require a written exception from the Head of Global Compliance before working remotely. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 5: Compensation Basics

Salaries are reviewed annually every March, with changes effective the following pay cycle. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Referral bonuses are two thousand dollars for a successful technical hire and one thousand dollars for all other roles. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Overtime for non-exempt employees is paid at one and a half times the base hourly rate. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 6: Health and Wellness Benefits

Full-time employees are eligible for health insurance starting on their first day of employment. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

The company contributes eighty-five percent of the premium for the employee and fifty percent for dependents. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

An annual wellness stipend of four hundred dollars can be used for gym memberships or mental health services. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 7: Vacation and Leave

Employees accrue two paid vacation days per month of service, up to a maximum of twenty-four days per year. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Unused vacation days roll over up to a cap of ten days into the following year. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Primary caregiver parental leave is sixteen weeks paid; secondary caregiver leave is six weeks paid. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 8: Performance Reviews

Formal performance reviews happen twice a year, in June and December. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

A rating of 'needs improvement' triggers a mandatory thirty-day improvement plan with weekly check-ins. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Promotions are decided in a calibration meeting attended by at least three people managers. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 9: Equipment and IT

Standard equipment requests ship within four business days through the IT helpdesk portal. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Company laptops must have full-disk encryption enabled before leaving the IT department. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

A lost or stolen device must be reported to IT Security within two hours of discovery. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 10: Business Travel

Business travel under one thousand dollars requires only the direct manager's approval. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Travel to a restricted-destination requires pre-approval from both the manager and the security team. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

The most recent policy review raised the business-class threshold from eight hours to ten hours of flight time. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 11: Code of Conduct

Conflicts of interest must be disclosed to HR within ten business days of becoming aware of them. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Gifts from vendors over seventy-five dollars in value must be declined or turned over to the office manager. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Violations are investigated by a three-person panel that never includes the employee's direct manager. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 12: Data Security

All customer data access requires multi-factor authentication without exception. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Security incidents must be reported within one hour of discovery, before notifying anyone outside the security team. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Access to the production database is reviewed and re-certified every ninety days. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 13: Learning and Development

Each employee has an annual learning budget of one thousand two hundred dollars. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Internal mentorship program applications open twice a year, in February and August. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Conference attendance over three thousand dollars requires Vice President approval. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 14: Offboarding

Exit interviews are conducted by HR, never by the departing employee's direct manager. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

All company equipment must be returned within five business days of the last day of employment. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Final paychecks are issued within the timeframe required by the employee's local jurisdiction, and in no case later than ten business days. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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Chapter 15: Workplace Safety

Every office location runs a fire drill at least twice per year. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Ergonomic equipment requests are approved automatically up to a budget of three hundred dollars. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

Workplace injuries must be reported to the office manager within twenty-four hours. This section exists to provide additional context and should be read in conjunction with the surrounding chapter. Northwind Collective reviews this handbook annually and reserves the right to update any section with reasonable notice to employees. Nothing in this handbook constitutes a guarantee of continued employment, and local law always takes precedence where it conflicts with any statement made here. Employees with questions about any section should contact their HR business partner rather than relying on informal guidance from colleagues.

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